



A Brie Grows in Brooklyn

"Mabel's not crazy... she's unusual."

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Families Are Worse Than Lawyers

Whenever I hear someone vehemently defending privacy, I always get suspicious. Because why do people need “privacy”? Usually to hide something they’re doing that is damaging to other people or living beings. People want to do horrible things to other people without anyone knowing about it. And when the truth is revealed, the only weapon they have is to scream about privacy.



Over my many years writing this blog, my family has often come after me for not keeping their privacy. In fact, my blog is used an excuse for other people’s bad behavior. My sister is getting sued in multiple states by the man she had a child with? It’s because of my blog.

Well, I’m not going to stop fucking writing it. I have very little power in my life, but I have the power to tell my own story.

RECENTLY LIKED



duckbeater

Four Short Stories

I’ve been sharing quick, minimally constructed stories with my friend Peter, as a way of batting away the rust around my writing. Now that I’ve sat with them for a week or more, and tinkered with them not at all, I’m ready to graduate them to Duck Beater, my horcrux, I mean my blog.

I HAVE RECENTLY MET SOME VERY POWERFUL GODS

Oh, I stopped going. I gave up the gym because I wasn’t changing. What was my libido then? Tortured, I think, by coltish undergrads in form-fitting sweatpants. Weirdly, I noticed my mood improved if I looked at dogs. If I saw beautiful, loyal dogs in the evenings, open and knowable and kind—I felt my soul swell with every passing. It was a harder kick than studying strangers on the stationary bikes ahead of me. Weirder still, I developed a kind of superstition about these dogs on my nightly jogs. I sought them out, for the contact high. I would say to myself, “I’m gonna see five gods tonight.” Gods not dogs. “I’m gonna see six gods tonight.” I didn’t need to touch them but I did need to pass them and look into their eyes. “I’m gonna see seven gods tonight.” Anyway. That’s why I run outside.

PERFECT GAMES FOR COWORKERS WHO ARE IN LOVE

This one is called “Be Messy, Make Mistakes,” so named for the legend

For the past year or so, every few weeks, a creepy guy shows up at our apartment right as we are putting our kids to bed, and delivers me and Caleb with subpoenas to appear as witnesses in a court case involving my sister and her ex-boyfriend. The conventional wisdom in my family is that we can ignore them. They are not from a judge — yet. Everyone told us that we could throw them in the garbage.

Then the lawyers delivering the subpoenas set a court date to compel us to appear. Mine is next week. When Caleb saw this, he got very angry, and said that we were going to just got to the depositions, and get them over with.

When I told my family about this, they wanted to have a quorum so that they could scream at us for betraying the family. My family called me multiple times to scream at me that I didn’t know what I was talking about, I could just throw out the paperwork, and ignore the subpoena.

Caleb and I consulted multiple friends who are lawyers. All of them went to the best law firms in the country, have done clerkships, and work at the best firms in the Southern District of New York City. They all told us we have to appear. Unanimously. Without hesitation. We cannot ignore the subpoenas. One way or the other, we will be deposed.

“Any smart lawyer would tell you to throw it in the garbage,” my dad just yelled at me when I told him that I had spoken to another lawyer friend about the deposition. I called him in a last ditch effort to get him to help us to hire a lawyer.

Because we are not involved in this because we did something wrong. We are involved in this because my sister and the man she had a child with did something wrong. Many things wrong. I really wish I could write about the things they did wrong because they are truly unbelievable, and also hilarious, but I don’t want to get fucking sued anymore.

What we did do was take care of my sister throughout her pregnancy, and when she first had her baby. I mean, maybe I did some shitty things, but Caleb definitely did not.

And all of that money we saved? Now we have to use it to hire a lawyer.

I finally got mad at my father over the phone. “I am fucking sick of dealing with this bullshit,” I screamed back at him.

“If you didn’t write bad things about the blog on the family, none of this would be happening!” he screamed back at me.

But here’s the truth — what I write on the blog doesn’t matter one bit. Every single bad thing I could have even thought of writing was already written directly by my sister to her ex-boyfriend in text messages. Those are much stronger pieces of evidence. The difference? They’re private! So much better for everyone, right?

WRONG. It doesn’t matter to the court. The reason why we’re getting subpoenaed, in the end, is because my sister fucking named Caleb and I as witnesses.

If you have any advice, I would love to hear it. But I am fucking mad.

#My life

Jan 15th, 2020



MORE YOU MIGHT LIKE

I Think It’s Normal For Parents To Have Fantasies About Getting to Rest in a Hospital With the Coronavirus

on a coffee mug. The rules are simple:

1. Wait for it.
2. Wait a day more for it.
3. The comparison rankles, but it’s impossibly obvious: You’re design lead looks like a young Joseph Stalin (of the 1902 mugshot). Same wavy hair, oiled and swept away from the face, the sides short enough to reveal perfect “number 6” ears. Then the well-groomed beard; the merry dark eyes; the propensity for scarves worn under woolen coats, slightly too large.
4. Say: “You look like a young Joseph Stalin.” There’s no taking it back. “See.”
5. Present the results of a quick Google search (two tabs you’ve already opened).
6. “That’s pretty wild!”
7. “You’re really a dead ringer.”
8. “Well, my family’s Russian.”
9. “Mm, so—so there could be—”
10. “A history that ties me to a war criminal, yes.”
11. You’re sitting side by side now with the perfect excuse to study his face, then the face of young Soso. For this photo, the Okhrana picked up Stalin just after the Batumi Massacre, and his expression, you find, is alight with the flame of revolution. For the sake of comparison, you’re allowed to stare deeply, dreamily into your design lead’s eyes again.
12. While he’s here, review some of the updated marketing collateral. Every item earns an affectionate knee touch. (Seriously, he taps your kneecap.)
13. You say, “New photo.”
14. He taps.
15. You say, “Colors print ready.”
16. He taps.
17. You say, “Ts and Cs.”
18. He taps.

Neither of you wins if he leaves his wife and kids.

WHEN THE SHARK BITES

One narrative that preoccupied me during my first serious relationship had to do with the Wright brothers—what the brothers were like as gawky teens. How they celebrated Halloween, where they rode bikes, cemeteries they explored on dares—that sort of thing. I was just out of college and crushing, apparently, on Wilbur, whose photo I’d seen at the Wayne County Historical Museum. I hungered for anachronism. I hungered, too, for love, and so gobbled up a dashing young man in Mississippi. While he fulfilled his tenure in Teach for America, I waited tables in Ohio and, when the spirit

My computer is about to die, and I left my charger in Savannah. My life has just been nonstop stressful, and I have a feeling it’s going to get worse because of this coronavirus. It doesn’t matter if it gets serious or not in New York. People are already afraid, and acting on their fear. You cannot buy hand sanitizer and masks anymore; you also can’t buy dried pasta, beans, or anything that comes in a can. Margarita brought her son with her to work this morning. She said that people on the subway and bus were yelling at her for having a kid on public transportation. I tried to tell her that the coronavirus is gentle on kids, but she is afraid, because her son has had many respiratory illnesses in the past, and his doctor sent out a note yesterday saying that the coronavirus can affect children with a history of respiratory illnesses.



(OMG can you imagine the median IQ of the people who are actually boarding cruise ships right now?)

I’m going to drive her home to New Jersey today, at the end of the day, and I don’t know if, or when, she will feel comfortable coming back to work.

I know she’ll want to work, because she needs the money, so I’m going to figure out a way that I can maybe bring the kids to her house, and maybe work there.

This should be easy when they shut down the schools, which seems like an eventuality.

Yesterday, there were many nannies hanging out outside of the gates of the playground. Cass started following one of them around, and she told me that her boss told her not to take her child into any playgrounds, or on the swings.

You only give those sorts of instructions to people if you have no fucking idea how hard it is to take care of a child in isolation for an entire day.

“The privilege of the people in this neighborhood,” someone said to me this morning. “They don’t have to worry about anything, so they’re almost relishing in the disaster.”

And it’s true. The coronavirus is big entertainment. Even Rachel Maddow dropped her regularly scheduled Trump fixation to talk open her show with the coronavirus last night.

This morning, the news seems stagnant. Maybe nothing bad will actually happen here. But it seems pretty certain that the coronavirus is going to become endemic. Why certain? I mean, Trump is in power. If the virus gets only a little bit worse, he could use it to seize absolute power.

I’m scared all of the time these days. Oh, by the way, my weekend alone in Savannah was fantastic.

#Coronavirus #My life



If You Scream at People on the Internet About Bernie

moved me, drove out to Dayton to explore the Wright archives.

This was a long time ago, when I was really into Thomas Pynchon and took everything for a sign. Everything conferred a “storm system of group suffering and need,” and there I was, pockets full of cash tips, full up of suffering and need, lamenting the distance from my lover and staunching an uncanny stream of rejection letters from graduate writing programs. Nobody wanted to fund my historiographic metafiction. And who could blame them.

The Wrights were awkward teenagers torqued more fabulously awkward by their mother’s slow death, their father’s increased absences, and the unsuccessful pursuits of their older brothers, who seemed to fail at everything they tried. Wilbur and Orville read widely enough to know their fortunes were unhappy (indeed, they sometimes signed their letters “Smike”). They lived in a small, comfortable city that elevated their ambitions to a high, miserable plateau, and their attempts to paper over poisoned circumstances—to write themselves an antidote—became a project that possibly saved themselves and their younger sister Katherine from fates like those in Dickens’ sentimental tragedies.

The stories I wrote, taken all together, would form *The Falconers*, a psychological novel that connected slender, depressed fellows to future, strapping heroes. How do lowly men become legends? How do cycling-obsessed boys conquer the skies? (It was that kind of story, with zits.) Thrillingly, my boyfriend moved to Falconer Avenue, just across from the middle school in Holly Springs. Every other month I made the eleven-hour drive, accepting blow jobs and raw dogs and golden showers as reward—monoliths of frantic, first-time sex to confirm our completely successful relationship. And this frosting? Was it frosting! I wrote chapters for *The Falconers* on Falconer Avenue. The world made perfect sense.

Of course, none of it “came to pass,” as Pynchon’s narrator in *Against the Day* is fond of saying. The novel fell apart. The boyfriend and I broke up. Still, when I revisit Wright letters and Wright biographies, I’m hounded by a mysterious and entirely inappropriate erection—that is, a kind of Pynchonian kink.

AFTER PICKING A FIGHT IN A BAR

People were gentler with me, I think, with my black eye. It was the week between Christmas and the New Year,

Sanders, You Deserve the DMV

I have ten minutes to write because my life is a fucking shit show right now. I want to say that politics has gone from being really scary to merely funny and sad in the past few days, and I’m grateful for that.



One thing I was thinking about when I was at the DMV yesterday, trying to renew my license for my flight to Savannah tomorrow morning, was that they should not do mock elections in high school because then the youths don’t take real elections that seriously. Another thing I was thinking about was that poor Bernie Sanders might have bleeding ears having to listen to all of his fucking supporters tell him about their dreams. Another thing I was thinking about was that if Bernie Sanders wins the election, he’s going to owe all of those people — the vegans, the white race warriors, the community activists, those whose parents paid for great educations but the best school they got into was Colgate, the Bernie Bros, the girls who love Bernie Bros because they don’t know they have daddy issues, the Baby Boomers who have been smoking pot for decades, the woman with 15 cats — positions in his administration.



I was thinking about this because sitting in the DMV, I was pondering how badly it was fucking run. No one working there knew the right answer to any question. There were a number of clearly mentally ill people who were just hanging out on the benches. The wait times were 2 hours long. I could not find out any clear information on the DMV website because it was a fucking disaster. It looked like some 60-year-old computer programmer had just like slashed banners everywhere using his 1982 IBM computing machine.

MENU

Department of Motor Vehicles

!

URGENT: Your regular New York State license or ID card will not allow you to fly starting October 2020. Get a REAL ID or Enhanced Driver License now!

!

ALERT: New office locations are now accepting reservations for license and permit transactions at the Adam Clayton Powell Jr. State Office Building in Harlem, Empire State College in Selden, and Shirley A. Chisholm State Office Building in Brooklyn.

I was thinking like, “Who the Fuck is making us get these REAL IDs.” In case you are not aware, if you don’t have a REAL ID, which is literally just an ID with a star in the right hand corner, you cannot fly domestically after October 2020. In order to get one, you have to show a passport, your birth certificate, and proof of your social security number, which HONESTLY WHO HAS ALL OF THAT FUCKING INFORMATION ON HAND. My mother still has my birth certificate locked in a security deposit box somewhere in

I had obviously been in a row, not elbowed, not tripped, and so in addition to looking smaller and darker and sadder than is usual for the holidays, I also looked more crazed and vicious. Why this would compel others to treat me gently does not signify a particular gentleness, or generosity, on their parts—but rather, I detected, a means to protect themselves. If I was not able to defend myself then surely they could defend against me. Kindness is a soft weapon. I rarely wielded it but was nonetheless always disarmed by it. Gentleness did not make me more gentle. I spent the week puzzled by unnecessary soft gestures and soothing voices. I spent the week reminding myself my special treatment was because I looked beat down, not because I was special. Besides, what could that mean? “Special.” Chosen, preferred, anointed, deserving, etc. I sometimes thought about what the world owed me, that week. I landed on “abstention.” Not mercy or forgiveness but rather a quiet space to be alone in earnest, all obligations off, responsibilities tamped down, remission. I had the week off work, which, my brother let me know, was a kind of mercy, because it’s always professionally suspect to arrive at work with a shiner. Colleagues ask questions and bosses harbor suspicions. I was fortunate in that my face could recuperate without scrutiny.

7 notes

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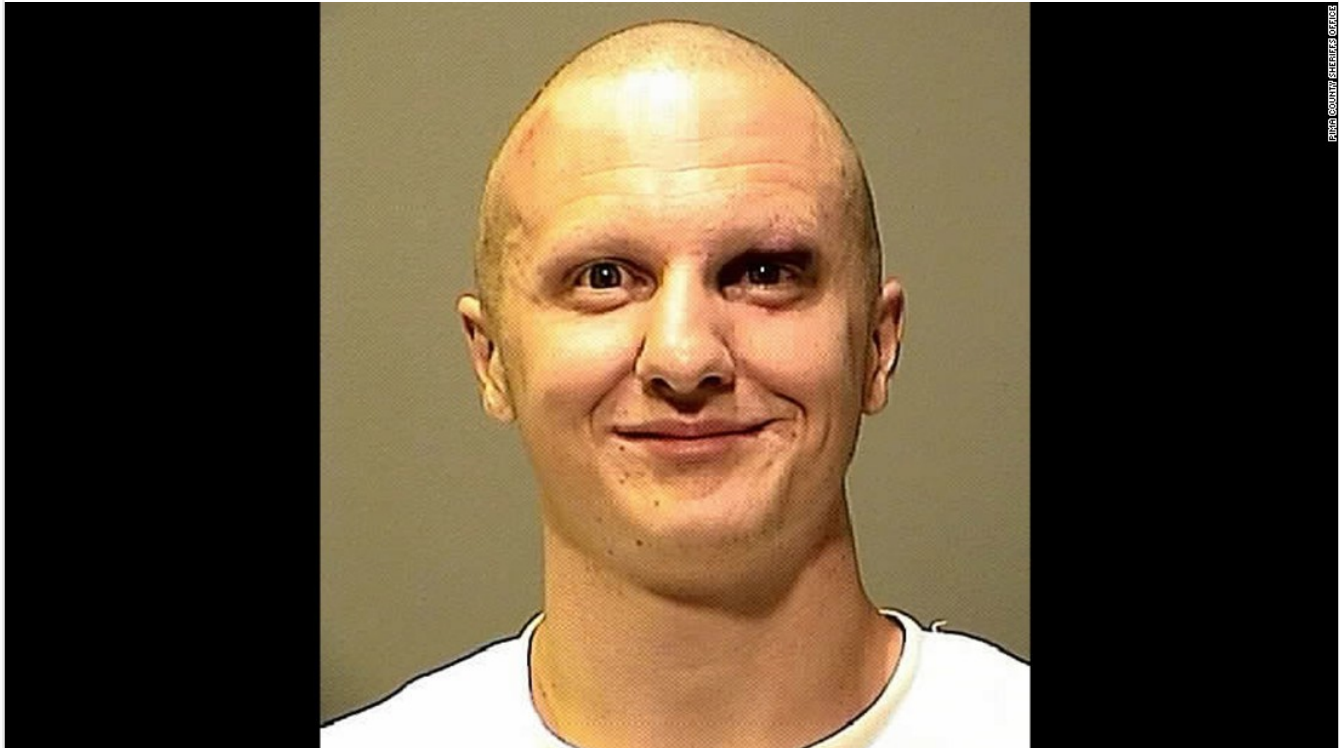
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♡

Westchester, and honestly I would not be surprised if my sister ate the key.

At first, I wanted to blame Cuomo for making me do this. I thought maybe he was raising money from it. Then I was like, “Nah, no way man, it’s Trump and the idiots in his administration.”

Then I did some research, and realized the REAL ID law was passed in 2005 by Congress. 2005! By Congress! Back then, everyone thought that the most dangerous thing was an Arab wearing a thoub boarding your flight in Oklahoma, but now everyone knows the fucking most dangerous thing is a white man with a soft stomach and acne scars born in the US of A walking into a restaurant carrying a fucking legal AK-47. HOW THEY GONNA CHECK THOSE PEOPLE?



Everyone seems to think these days that the government is going to cure systemic racism, and save the climate, and lift us from the depths of our misery, but we’ve forgotten what government really does, which is pass inane and stupid laws that make all of our lives a fucking beuracratic nightmare. I KNOW I DIDN’T SPELL BEURACRATIC RIGHT. I KNOW THAT’S NOT THE ONLY THING GOVERNMENT DOES.

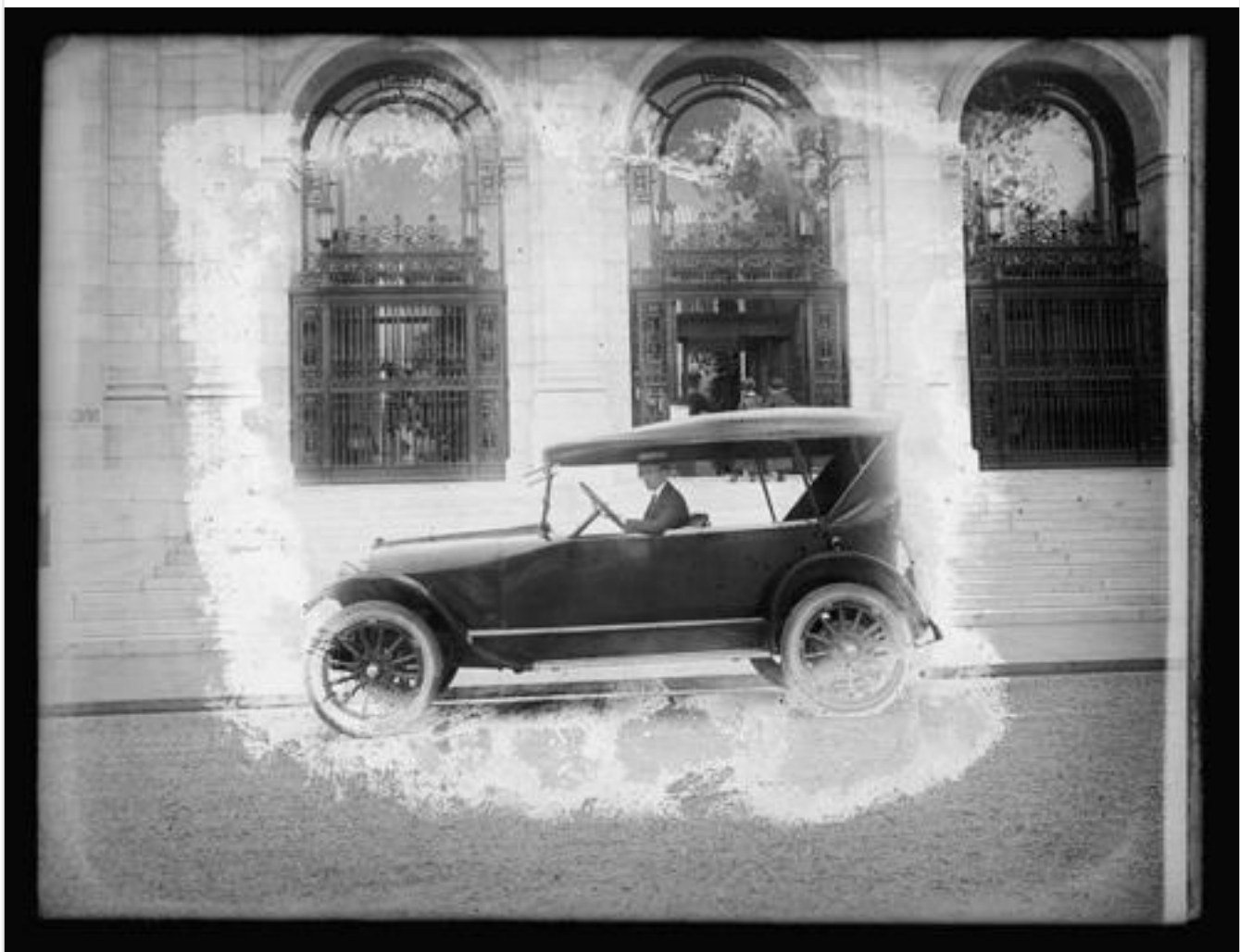
Anyway, if I have ever thought of an argument not to elect Bernie Sanders, the best one I’ve thought of is the REAL ID. Seriously, think about this, would you rather the nurse who is wiping Joe Biden’s drool send legislation through congress, or would you rather the person screaming at you about white privilege on the Internet? I’ll let you make that decision.

#My life #Bernie Sanders #Politics

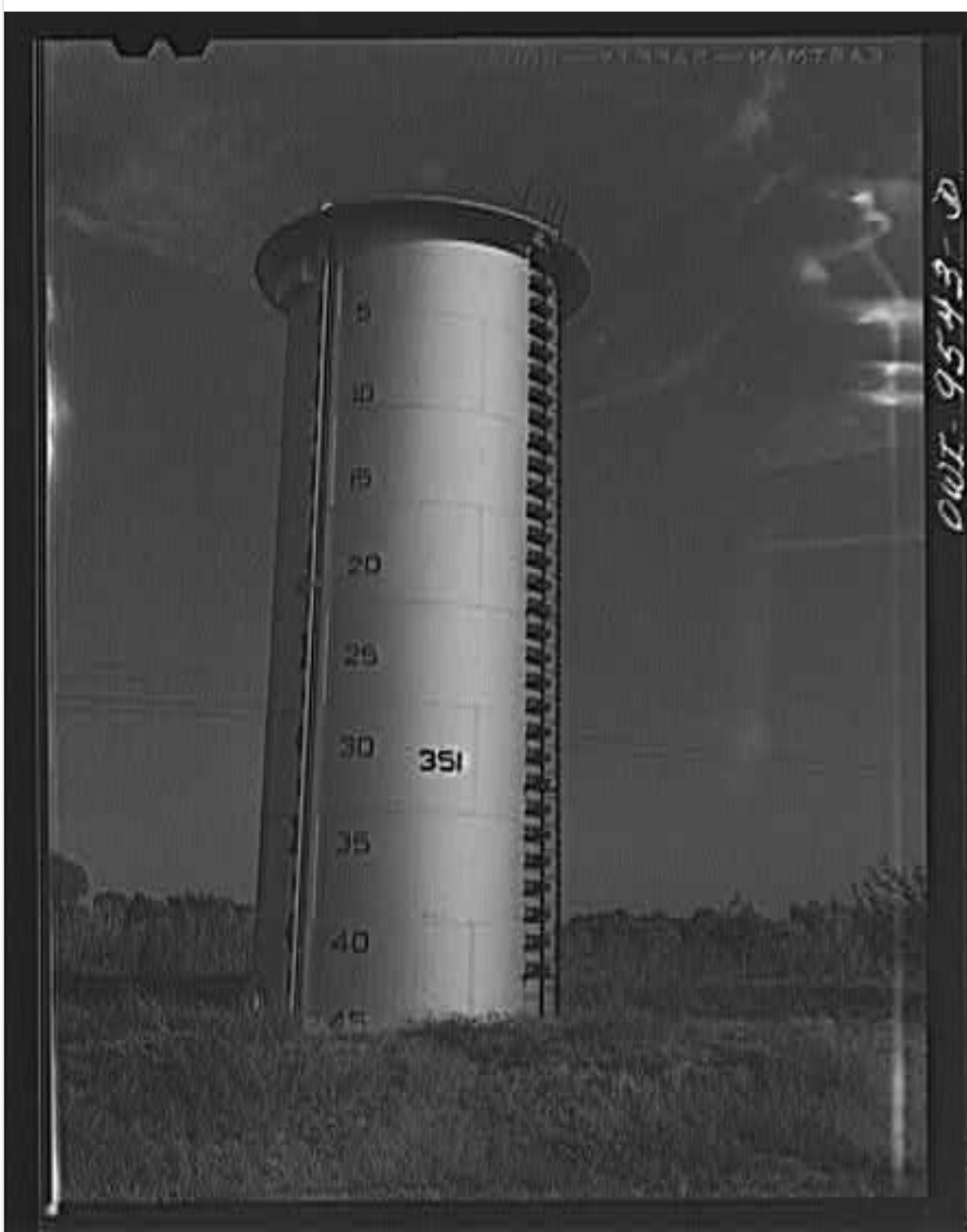
1 note



24 Hours From Tulsa (The Devil Went On)



I’m going to Tulsa tomorrow. On a private plane. I normally wouldn’t brag about that, but that is pretty fucking baller. Who gets to go to Tulsa on a private plane? Basically no one. Except me. And a few other people. Tomorrow. I feel comfortable basking in the glory of this because it will no doubt be the first and only time in my life I will fly anything but coach.



I'm going for the opening of the Philbrook Museum Downtown, a satellite of the city's main art institution. I'm writing a piece on it for a publication, so you'll have to wait to hear more on that until it comes out.



[Keep reading](#)

#Tulsa #Oklahoma #Douglas Sirk #My life

3 notes



Happy Memories: Lavender Underpants and a Night With a Man Named Lenny



There is literally nothing interesting going on in my life right now besides one interesting thing I promised I wouldn’t write about. And I’ve been trapped all day on the Upper East Side, paralyzed by a crippling inability to choose where to eat from the many disgusting places on 2nd avenue above 86th street. I went to the bodega, and they had a very limited soft drink selection, and it made me want to return to Brooklyn.



So instead of writing a boring post about how much I love walking my dog in my neighborhood, or the formulaic film “The Way Way Back,” which I saw last week, I’m going to post part of one of the essays that I wrote a few weeks ago. No one seems to like it, which is ok with me, because I don’t really like it either.



This post has sex in it, so Dad, if you’re reading this in secret, please do not read further. Same goes for brothers, uncles, or male cousins. Or female cousins. Nana? Are you out there? My crazy cousin Shawn who lives with eighteen turtles in Arizona, however, is welcome to read it.



[Keep reading](#)

#Wong Kar Wai #Love #Sex #My life

4 notes



What’s On My Fridge

(For your meme, [NSOMN](#))

It’s mostly just a photo album writ large, inspired, in part, by a scene from Cameron Crowe’s *Vanilla Sky*, the one in which Tom Cruise goes to Penelope Cruise’s apartment, and spends a while looking at a montage of pictures on her wall. Afterwards, he falls madly in love with her. Since then, it’s been a dream of mine to have a man fall in love with me because my life looks so great magnetized on the front of a refrigerator.



My apartment is so small that I couldn't take a picture of the whole fridge without breaking a hole into the bathroom wall, so I had to take detail shots. In this picture:

- Strips from Lakeside Lounge with Shark Mobczak, Hannah, Lance and Jamie
- Polaroids my sister took of our parent's house,
- A photo booth strip from Ryan McGinness' "Go Fishing" Party last year at his studio in Chinatown
- a test shot from a photo shoot I did for Lucky Magazine
- a set of magnets of famous Impressionist paintings my closest friend Alison gave me when she moved to Denver
- A picture of me with both my Mom and Dad in those halcyon days before Blara was born (in the picture with my Mom, she's 8 months pregnant with Blara. If you touched her stomach, the flesh would burn off your hand.)
- A piece of wax paper from the "Brie" sandwich at No. 7 sub at the Ace Hotel

[Keep reading](#)

#what's on your fridge #my life

4 notes



If I'm Not a Scorpio Anymore, Then Who the F—K Am I?



All of my life, I've been a Scorpio.

I've used my star sign to explain away all of my character flaws, and to comfort myself when men have stopped calling me.

“He’s a Pisces, a Scorpio is just too much for him,” I’ve sobbed into the turquoise and lavender fur of the Sulley from *Monsters Inc.* stuffed animal I sleep with every night. I’m 28 years old.

I’ve used being a Scorpio to explain that time in college when I took 3 Tylenol PM after getting in a fight with my boyfriend, and then ran over to his house, wide-awake and wild-eyed, only to catch him playing video games with his roommates.

“I can’t control my passions!” I screamed at him. “I’m running around the streets in my pajamas, hallucinating my face off, and it’s all because I’m a Scorpio! My anger is a dangerous force!”



[Keep reading](#)

#New Zodiac Signs #Ophiuchus #my life

16 notes

... ↺ ❤

Evening Comes Over the BQE, And It Can Be Kind Of Beautiful



For a while this past Saturday, I sat and talked with my brother Stuprendan. He is 16-years-old, and probably the wisest person I’ve ever met in my life.



In the late afternoon sunlight of my parent’s formal dining room, bathed in hues of blue and yellow, I tinkered with the Playmobile Hospital set up on the table of the center of the room, and listened while he talked about emotional intelligence. He’s studying psychology in school right now, which is a topic in which he excels, likes most of the things he studies. A few years ago, he handed in a paper about the emotional trauma of visiting Normandy, and his teacher at the time told my parents it was the best work she had read in her 35 years of teaching.



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#Bipolar II #Depression #Trauma #my life

15 notes

... ↻ ❤

If You Wear Headphones With Your Running Leggings, You Can’t Hear Men Yelling At You From Autobody Shops On Van Brunt Street

One of my big plans for changing my life (this week) is getting out of the house more. So rather than changing out of my nightgown, and into my pajamas, I’m starting my day by putting on my running clothes. Real clothes sets the bar too high.

This morning, I had a brief lull in emails, so I decided to take Frankenmonster out for a walk. We went to Red Hook, my favorite place on earth, where we saw many beautiful things.



A red bike under a tree.



A cruise ship looming over deserted warehouses, its own empty street.





A birthday present for me.

(By the way, this shop just opened, and it is SO beautiful.)



The harbor whipped like meringue by the wind.



Not a shade of its cerulean manipulated by me.

#Jogging Leggings #Papillionaire #Red Hook #Van Brunt Street #my lif

5 notes



My Daughter Does Screwball

I think the past week has been one of the happiest of my life. I feel content in my routine. I feel grateful. I don't feel burdened by ambition. I am singing a lot. I am not exhausted.



I feel so lucky to be Cleo's mother, which is perhaps not the most interesting thing to read about, but the thing I most want to record. There are a lot of things no one tells you about motherhood. For example, how many bananas you will buy every week — upwards of 50, in my case. Or how many of your calories will come from eating half chewed food off the floor.

Another thing no one tells you is that motherhood has an inevitable rhythm, as does life. There are times when it seems impossible, and there are times when it is pure joy. These past few weeks with my little Cleo Anne have been pure joy.



Cleo Anne hasn't shown any signs of being a genius. She can't play the piano, and she can't say many words. She doesn't make towers of blocks, and she can't make any animal sounds that correspond to the animal that makes them. But she is *funny*. Like, purposefully funny. Screwball funny. She uses her body, and her face, and her eyebrows, to make people laugh. She sits in her high chair, where she likes to be when we are home, likely so that she can survey her domain, and she makes Caleb and I laugh. She throws Cheerios on the floor, and then shakes her finger, "No, no, no!" She squints her eyes. She imitates Caleb yawning.

I thought maybe we only thought Cleo was funny. But last night, I realized otherwise on a walk from a playdate with our friends Sheena and Naomi. Sheena and I have a special bond of love, and Naomi and Cleo also have a special bond of love. Cleo often knocks over Naomi with her head butts, which are her version of kisses. That’s another thing about Cleo that surprises and delights me — she is incredibly affectionate.



Nai is a little bit older than Cleo, and definitely smarter. She says, “Cleo, Cleo,” and often shows her friend how to do things the right way. For example, how to sit in a chair, or how to strum on a toy guitar. The two of them were so happy to be walking home unfettered last night. It was dark, but warm. The streets were lit by Christmas lights, and the pair of them stopped at every bodega to admire the lottery signs that covered the windows in bright primary colors. In a bar, there was a dog that barked at them. At the pet store, a manger filled with animal figurines. Cleo, knowing that she had Nai’s attention, began to perform.

“Wooooooo!!!” she trilled, arching her back and pointing up at a street light. Naomi started giggling uncontrollably, and the two of them went stomping up the street, trying out various movements with their bodies, and chuckling.



Sheena and I, following behind, were obviously enamored. I felt out

of my mind with joy, like life couldn't get any better than that three block walk up the street, following behind my daughter and her friend while they made each other laugh without language.

It's the simple things, really. My favorite kind of comedy is screwball, and I have a screwball daughter. I don't know how I got so lucky to have this life, but I am grateful, and I will try to remember these times when I think of complaining in the future.

#My life #Love #Family #Motherhood #Dear Cleo Anne

6 notes ... ↺ ♡



My sister came over to watch the Super Bowl last night. “Honestly, you need to stop posting so many pictures of Cleo, your whole feed is like, ‘baby, baby, baby,’” she told me.

“You are kind of fat, but you need to stop talking about it because it’s making people uncomfortable,” she said as I complained about being fat while stuffing nachos in my mouth.

My life is so small now; I’m so tired. My sister was a ray of sunshine in a weekend that otherwise was dominated by anxiety about trying to find literal space to write the three profiles that were due on Friday. It used to be so easy to get work done; now, even small assignments take so much time.

I had a thought the other day, while I was walking around with Cleo. She was sleeping. My brain was tired, and fuzzy, as it always is these days. I never sleep for more than four or five hours at a time. I thought about how before I had a baby, I thought it was a curse to be intelligent because intelligence leads to despair and depression. Now, that I am no longer intelligent, I realize I’m depressed and anxious even when I’m stupid.

I wouldn't trade anything for this child, however, who is calling me from her activity mat, wanting to be picked up, or fed, or who knows what else, I need some coffee.

#My life #Motherhood

9 notes ... ↺ ♡

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